
UCCC 1101

COMMUNICATION SKILLS

Notes/Handbook

1.0 COMMUNICATION

1.1 Introduction to Communication

In this section, we shall examine the field of communication to serve as a foundation to what follows in the course. Principally, we shall define communication; outline its elements, principles, and its importance in academic and life in general. We shall also briefly examine the various types of communication.

1.2 Objectives of the topic

At the end of this topic, you should be able to:

- a) Define communication
- b) Discuss the elements that constitute communication
- c) Explain the importance of communication in academics and in life in general
- d) Outline the important principles of communication
- e) Discuss the various types of communication

1.3 What is Communication?

The term communication comes from a Latin word '*communicare*' which means to make common or share. Therefore, communication is **a process** by which **meaning is exchanged** between individuals or an individual and a group through **a common system of symbols, signs, and behavior.**

- The definition of communication is shared in the Webster's Dictionary as "sending, giving, or exchanging information and ideas," which is often expressed nonverbally and verbally.
- A plethora of authors have defined communication including Gamble and Gamble, who define communication as a desirable or accidental transfer of meaning.
- Communication is also a process of sharing or exchanging ideas, information, knowledge, attitude or feelings through certain signs, symbols and behavior.
- Communication is more than transfer of ideas and thoughts; it is a dynamic process of action and interaction towards desired goals.

1.3.1 Key phrases of definition

- a) **Communication is a process:** it is an activity which is an exchange of meaning that is dynamic. Communication is therefore not static. Communication as a process is a concept whose critical element is the changing nature of its occurrence.
- b) **Communication involves meaning:** Meaning is shared understanding of message. The understanding of the meaning of another person's message only occurs when you elicit common meanings for words, phrases, and non-verbal messages.
- c) **Communication is a system of symbols, signs and behavior:** the system may be in form of language, gesture, demeanor, facial expressions etc.

1.3.2 Importance of Studying Communication

Communication is central to human life. You cannot avoid communication and you will engage in communication nearly every minute of every day in your life. In addition, communication plays a major role in every aspect of your life. Effective communication therefore both enhances your daily life and at the same time solves problems in your professional and personal life. Communication experts believe that poor communication is at the root of many of our problems.

Therefore, there are various reasons why studying communication is important:

- a) **Studying communication helps in understanding and insight of oneself and others.**
 - Self-awareness is the way we see ourselves. Most of our self-knowledge comes from communication with ourselves (intrapersonal communication) and communication with other people (interpersonal communication). The message and feedback we receive from others helps improve our self-concept.
- b) Studying communication and using it effectively can lead to more positive feelings of ourselves. **Effective communication can improve our self-worth** by enabling us to positively project ourselves in what is called **image management**.
- c) Studying communication can **increase our knowledge about human relationships** because studying communication includes learning about how people relate with one another and about what communication is appropriate for a given situation.
- d) Studying communication can **teach us important life skills**. For instance, it can help us **acquire problem solving skills**. Studying communication is also instrumental in helping

us acquire important life skills such as **decision-making skills, public speaking** etc. All these skills are important in academic and career development.

- e) Studying communication **can help us succeed professionally**. Employers regard highly written, oral, and other communication competencies. The ability to listen and analyze messages is usually considered an essential professional skill. Entrepreneurs too regard communication skills as top priority skills for success.
- f) Poor communication may lead to misunderstanding, frustration, being ignored by others, unsuccessful careers, among many other negative consequences.

1.4 Objectives of Communication

Whether we are speaking, writing, persuading, informing, entertaining, explaining, convincing, educating or any other objective behind the communication, we always have four general objectives:

- To be received (heard or read)
- To be understood
- To be accepted
- To get action (change behavior or attitude)

1.5 Elements of Communication

Elements of communication are the components that constitute the communication process. These are:

a) **People**

These are the **participants** in the communication process. People are involved in communication in two roles. They are **sources** and **receivers** of messages. Sources initiate/compose the intended message. S/he encodes the message, while receivers are the intended target of messages, i.e., a receiver is the person who receives, decodes, comprehends and attaches meaning to the message sent. The participants' knowledge, interest and emotional state will affect how the message is sent or received. In the communication process, people are sources and receivers of a message simultaneously and continually.

b) **Message**

This is the verbal or non-verbal form of idea, thought or feeling that one person (source) wishes to communicate to a group of people (receivers). The message, therefore, is the **content** of interaction. A message may be easy to understand or long and complex, it may also be intentional or un-intentional.

c) **Channel**

This is how a message moves from a source to a receiver. It is also called the **medium of transmission**. The medium may be in form of sound waves (in oral-auditory messages) or as light waves (in visual communication such as written communication).

d) **Feedback**

This is the receiver's verbal, non-verbal or written **response** to the message from the source. Feedback is part of any communication situation such that even non-response is feedback.

e) **Code**

This is the **systematic arrangement of symbols** used by the source or receiver to create meaning in the mind of another person(s) or receiver(s). The code may be in form of

- i) Language you choose to communicate in e.g., English, Kiswahili or *Sheng*.
- ii) Grammatical structure, for instance, a statement, question etc.
- iii) Words and phrases you choose to use.
- iv) Non-verbal codes you may choose.

f) **Encoding and decoding**

Encoding is the act of putting ideas and thoughts into a code, while decoding is interpreting/making sense those ideas or thoughts.

g) **Noise**

Noise is any interference in encoding or decoding process that reduces the clarity of a message. Noise can be in the form of:

- i) **Physical noise**, which can be in form of distracting sounds or sights. Such noise is usually easier to prevent in a speaking or listening situation. For example, closing doors to a noisy room, wearing ear plugs etc.
- ii) **Psychological/noise**, mental and emotional interferences that distract communication, such as daydreaming, pain, hunger and the like.

- iii) **Semantic noise**, which is the use of expressions that are unknown to the receiver or are too complex in grammatical structure. They include language differences, inattention and misunderstanding caused by different interpretations of a word or an expression. Cultural diversity can also lead to semantic noise.

1.6 Principles of communication

There are important properties of communication that we need to keep in mind as we study and employ communication. The properties constitute the invaluable attributes of communication:

- a) **Communication is inescapable**: communication is always occurring in human life at various levels, for instance, at the intra-personal level when you are thinking, planning, meditating, as well as when you are observing, gathering information, and making conclusions. It also occurs at the interpersonal level as you interact with one another.
- b) **Communication is irreversible**: you cannot take back something once it is communicated. Even if you can, what has been communicated cannot entirely be erased. Traces of the effect of the communication will always remain.
- c) **Communication is dynamic**: all elements in communication (i.e., setting, participants, their knowledge, their roles etc.) affect each other as communication progresses.
- d) **Every communication interaction has a content dimension and relationship dimension**: Content dimension is the information or message that a source desires to communicate, which must be packaged in a strategic manner to elicit a desired reaction. The relationship dimension of communication constitutes the elements in the communication that seek to signal and acknowledge the state of the social relation between the communicating parties. The relationship dimension 'oils' the attainment of communication goals. For instance, if you lecturer entered the lecturer room with unzipped trousers and you wanted to alert him to this fact, you will not just blurt out to him the content of what you want to say to him! You will need to do a lot of damage control about the awkward situation, while at the same time recognizing his superior position in relation to you as a student. Just think of the exact kind of language you would use and point out the content and relationship dimension of what you will say.

- e) **Communication is contextual:** communication does not occur in a vacuum. It involves various aspects of context in communication. The context of communication is the environment in which communication takes place. The context of communication involves:
- i) **Psychological context:** that is the needs, desires, values, personality, and so on that people communicate and bring to the communication activity.
 - ii) **Situational context:** this involves the place and time of communication, which affects what and how we communicate.
 - iii) **Environmental context:** this involves the physical features of the communication setting, such as, noise level, cultural context, objects available in setting etc.
- f) **Communication is complicated:** Communication is complicated in several respects. For instance:
- i) It involves choice about multiple aspects of message i.e., we must make verbal and code choices, as well as non-verbal behavioral aspects to be used in communication. We also must make choices of channel, and all these aspects must be combined strategically to pass across a unified message.
 - ii) Communication is also complicated because of our differing perception of the same object that we may wish to communicate about.

1.7 Types of Communication

Communication can be categorized in three ways.

- a) By the number of people involved in the communication process.
 - b) By the channel or medium used in the communication process.
 - c) By direction of flow.
- a) **Communication categorized by number of people involved:**
- i) **Intrapersonal communication:** this is the process of sharing meaning within oneself in the mind, which involves such activities as reflection, problem solving, planning, and solving internal conflict among others. This is a continuous process we always engage in but rarely realize we are involved in it.
 - ii) **Inter-personal communication:** this involves exchanging meaning between at least two people in a situation that allows mutual opportunities for both speaking and listening. Interpersonal communication can be of two types:

- **Dyadic communication:** involves two people in communication such as a doctor and a patient, a lecturer and a student.
 - **Small group communication** involves three to ten people such communication includes that which takes place in families and work groups.
- iii) **Public communication:** it involves one person communicating to a large group of people.
- iv) **Mass communication:** this is communication mediated via a technological transmission system involving a source (professional communicator often representing an organization), and many unseen receivers spread over a wide geographical area. The transmission system might be in the form of electronic, audio, audio-visual signal or visual technologies such as publication in form of books or newspapers.

b) **Communication Categorized by Channel or Medium**

Communications creates links between people for different functions or purposes. If several links are missing, broken or not aligned properly, the communication becomes wobbly and may eventually break. The following are communication situations that represent a different flow of communication depending on the purpose:

- i) **Verbal communication:** this type of communication relies on the oral-auditory signal for communication.
- ii) **Graphic communication:** this communication is also known as visual communication. It involves visual representation of ideas facts and objects other than written communication e.g., cartoons, graphs, charts, models, objects etc.
- iii) **Written communication:** this is the use of visual symbols, representing language, on a surface which is read by receivers.
- iv) **Non-verbal communication:** this is the use of visual or oral auditory signals that do not primarily rely on language or verbalized message for communication to take place.

The term verbal communication is often used broadly to capture all spoken and written forms of communication, and used in opposition to non-verbal.

Non-verbal communication may sometimes contradict and override verbal messages.

Non-verbal communication can be used effectively to reinforce one's verbal message, to express emotions and attitudes, and to express one's personality.

1.7.1 Categories of non-verbal communication

Paralanguage - Paralanguage or vocalics mainly includes use of vocal features such as pitch, volume, rate and intonation, as well as features such as laughing, crying, hesitating and sighing

Haptics - Haptics is communication through touching. Examples include handshakes, hugs, hand-holding, arms around shoulders etc.

Kinesics - Kinesics includes the study of posture, movement, gestures and facial expressions. For example sitting posture indicates attention or lack thereof, facial expressions capture emotions, gestures express a range of meaning e.g. a friendly wave.

Olfactics - Olfactics is the study of the influence of smell on communication behaviour.

Chronemics - Chronemics involves interpretation based on how we perceive time, and how we structure our time.

Proxemics - Proxemics is the study of how people use space. Territoriality and personal space are important concepts here. Territoriality refers to our need to establish and maintain certain spaces as our own. Personal space, on the other hand, is the distance one maintains between oneself and others.

1.7.2 Communication according to direction of flow

Communications creates links between people for different functions or purposes. If several links are missing, broken or not aligned properly, the communication becomes wobbly and may eventually break. The following are communication situations that represent a different flow of communication depending on the purpose:

i) **Upward communication**

This is communicating with people who rank above you, such as your boss or instructor.

ii) **Lateral or horizontal communication**

This is communicating with people who are at the same rank or level as you – your co-workers or classmates.

iii) **Downward communication**

This is communicating with people who rank below you, such as the people you might manage at work.

iv) **Internal communication**

This is a communication situation that takes place in a company or an organization. Internal communication is the transmittal of information between and among persons within a business or organization. It is used to accomplish company goals and objectives. For example, managers communicating deadline on assignments or employees seeking promotions.

v) **External communication**

This is the transfer of information to and from people outside the company or organization. The goal is to persuade the recipients to respond favorably to company needs. For example, a job advert tries to attract qualified personnel to fill a certain position.

vi) **Cross-cultural communication**

This refers to communicating, either in writing, verbally or non-verbally, with people who are from a culture different from your own. This calls for an understanding and respect of cultural differences and being adaptable.

vii) **Grapevine communication**

This refers to informal communication within a company/organization, where information spread bypasses the formal communication structure. It spreads in random ways, irrespective of the authority levels.

NOTE: The direction your communication flows at any given time will influence how you communicate – the words you use and the method you choose.

1.8 7 Cs of Communication

Effective communication must apply the following 7 essentials, whether you are speaking or writing. Using these 7Cs will ensure that your communication is coherent and easy to follow.

1. Clarity

This refers to being specific rather than vague while communicating.

You must communicate so clearly that you cannot be misunderstood, i.e., it is not enough to communicate so you can be understood.

Ask the following key questions to test how clear your communication is:

- Have you used familiar words, short sentences?
- Have you presented only one idea in each sentence?
- Have you avoided "business" and technical terms?
- Have you used the reader's language?

2. Completeness

Complete communication includes enough details so that the recipient will not need to ask for more information. For example – if you receive a message from your lecturer asking you to pick your graded papers on Wednesday, how do you know which Wednesday it should be?

To be complete, a communication should answer the following questions: Who? What? Where? When? Why? How? or How much?

Ask the following key questions to test how complete your communication is:

- Have you given all the facts?
- Have you covered the essentials?
- Have you answered all his/her questions?
- Did you PLAN what you said?

3. Conciseness

Concise communication avoids unnecessary words that could hamper the same communication. Such extra words may clutter the message and distort it all together. Conciseness makes the message more understandable and comprehensible.

For conciseness:

- Eliminate wordy expressions
- Include only relevant material
- Avoid unnecessary repetition

Look at the following examples:

WORDY	CONCISE
Due to the fact that	Because
In due course	Soon
At this time	Now
Few in number	Few
On a weekly basis	Weekly
In spite of the fact that	Although
Until such time as	Until
Meet together	Meet

In-class exercise:

Revise the following statement, which is too wordy and eliminate seven unnecessary words ('fillers').

"I am writing this letter to inform you that your airline tickets will be mailed ten days before your scheduled departure".

4. Consistency

All communication should be consistent in FACT, TREATMENT and SEQUENCE.

Consistency in fact refers to agreement with a source document or an established fact. For example, an exam scheduled for 31st April should be questioned since April has only 30 days.

Consistency in treatment means treating similar items the same way. For example, using the courtesy title (Mr., Mrs., Miss., or Ms.) with names of all recipients of a letter or indenting all paragraphs in a report.

Consistency in sequence refers to the arrangement of listings such as alphabetical, chronological or numerical order. For example, if an exam is scheduled for 3 days, the dates should be given in chronological order: June 14, June 15 and June 16.

5. Correctness

This refers to all the information in the message being accurate – the content, the spelling, the capitalization and the punctuation. The following guidelines can ensure your communication achieves correctness:

- Use the correct level of language
- Check accuracy of figures, facts and words
- Maintain acceptable writing mechanics
- There should be proper grammar, punctuation, spelling and paragraphing

Ask the following questions to test for correctness:

- Have you checked all facts for correctness?
- Have you spelled the reader's name correctly?
- Have you verified all numbers and amounts?
- Is the appearance of the letter effective? Is it clean, well-spaced?
- Have you checked your spelling, punctuation, grammar, etc.?

6. Consideration

This refers to the use of the 'You-attitude' instead of the 'I' or 'We-attitude'. Consideration applies sympathy, the human touch and understanding of human nature. It means the message is sent with the receiver in mind. You should try to visualize your readers; their desires, problems, emotions, circumstances and possible reaction to your communication.

The following actions can ensure that your communication is considerate:

- Focus on 'You-attitude' instead of 'I' or 'We'
- Show audience benefit or interest in the receiver
- Emphasize positive pleasant facts

Look at the following examples:

NEGATIVE EMOTION/EXPRESSION	TRANSFORMS INTO
Anxious	A little concerned, expectant
Confused	Curious
Destroyed	Set back
Disgusted	Surprised
Failure	Learning
I hate	I prefer
Insulted	Misunderstood
Lost	Searching
Painful	Uncomfortable
Stressed	Busy
GOOD WORD	GREAT WORD
Attractive	Gorgeous
Confident	Unstoppable
Curious	Fascinated
Fast	Ballistic
Fortunate	Blessed
Interesting	Captivating
Like	Relish
Nice	Fantastic
Quick	Explosive
Smart	Gifted

7. Courtesy

This always refers to the building of goodwill.

- Be sincerely tactful, thoughtful and appreciative
- Use expressions that show respect
- Choose non-discriminatory expressions

Ask the following questions to test your communication for courtesy:

- Will it win goodwill?
- Have you used positive, "pleasant-toned" words?
- Have you used "I appreciate," "please", and "thank you" somewhere in your message?
- Would you enjoy reading what you have said?

NOTE: Concreteness: (sometimes used in the place of consistency – either one of them is acceptable).

This refers to when communication is specific definite unambiguous and vivid rather than vague and general. The following guidelines lead to concreteness.

1. Use specific facts and figures
2. Put action in your verb
3. Choose vivid image building words.

Ask the following questions to test your communication for concreteness:

- Have you given the crisp details the client needs?
- Have you made the details razor and needle-sharp?
- Have you flashed word pictures, made facts vivid?

The chief art in communication is to know:

1. How much to put in.
2. What to leave out.
3. When to quit.

1.9 Specific barriers to communication

Human communication is fraught with problems and difficulties such as:

1. Differences in opinion

Our worldviews are largely determined by our past experiences. As vast as these experiences are, so are the perceptions and interpretations of the world that people have. Age, nationality, culture, education, occupation, sex, status, personality etc., all bring to bear the difference in perception.

2. Jumping to conclusions

We often see what we expect to see, thus hear what we expect to hear, rather than what is intended. This may lead us to unnecessary conclusions.

3. Stereotyping

Our experiences could run us the risk of treating different people as if they were the same.

4. Lack of knowledge

Communication is adversely affected if it is exchanged between persons whose knowledge of the subject is varied or whose backgrounds regarding the subject are too different.

It requires skill on the part of the communicator to be aware of the discrepancy between the levels of knowledge, thus communicate accordingly.

5. Lack of interest

This is lacking alertness to the message being sent. As an effective communicator, you should avoid assuming that your interest in the specific subject is everyone's interest, thus angle your message to appeal to the interests and needs of the receiver.

6. Difficulties with expression

This refers to difficulty expressing or conveying your message as clearly as possible. It includes lack of vocabulary as well as lack of confidence, both of which can be overcome by improving your vocabulary and preparing carefully respectively.

7. Emotions

Both the receiver and communicator could harbor strongly felt emotions that could prevent almost anything from being communicated. Such emotions could entirely distort the communication and should be avoided.

However, any audience knows that a speaker without emotion and enthusiasm is likely to be a dull speaker. Emotion just needs a clear balance.

8. Personality

Our personality traits/behaviors can affect the behavior of others in a communication situation. We may not be able to change the personalities of others, but at least we should be prepared to consider our own personality to see if change in behavior may result in more satisfactory relationships, thus better communication.

2.0 LISTENING SKILLS

2.1 Introduction

In this section, we are interested in discussing listening as an invaluable skill in the communication process. We shall also endeavor to show how listening is connected to critical thinking.

2.2 Objectives of the topic

By the end of this topic, you should be able to:

- a) Distinguish between hearing and listening
- b) Outline the importance of listening in our lives
- c) Explain the essential aspects in the listening process
- d) Discuss the various types of listening
- e) Demonstrate knowledge of effective listening strategies

2.3 Definition of Listening

Hearing is the act of receiving sound. **Listening** is the act of receiving sound, constructing meaning and responding to the spoken message. Listening also involves the ability to retain information as well as react emphatically to the spoken message.

2.4 Importance of Listening in our lives

- a) Listening is an essential task for effective communicators. We actually do spend the largest part of our time listening, for instance it has been observed that college students spend up to 50% of their time listening.
- b) Listening helps us build and maintain relationship. Part of our ability to build and retain relationships involves our ability to understand and respond empathetically to messages from others.
- c) Listening can help us determine whether people we are communicating with are honest or deceitful.
- d) Listening is an essential skill for success in academics and business world.
- e) Listening is directly linked to our ability to remember information.

2.5 The Listening Process

The listening process involves receiving oral stimuli (music, words or sounds) in the ear (*Hearing*). The ear translates the vibration from oral stimuli into sensation that is registered by the brain (*Listening*). The brain, using attention and working memory, interprets the sensation and gives it meaning (*Interpretation*). The interpreted message is then stored in short term memory for immediate use (*Retaining*) or long term memory for future recall (*Recalling*).

Important aspects of the Listening Process:

- a) **Attention** – At any one time there are many oral-auditory stimuli such that our mind must focus on specific stimuli and block others. This process is called **attention**. Attention is selective or automatic.
 - i) **Selective attention** – This is sustained focus we give to information we deem important. Selective attention can be obstructed by our mind's instinct to pay automatic attention to certain stimuli.
 - ii) **Automatic attention** – this is instinctive focus we give to stimuli signaling a change in our surrounding. We give automatic attention to stimuli that we deem important or that which we perceive to signal danger. Automatic attention, therefore, competes with selective attention.
- b) **Working memory** – This is the part of our consciousness that interprets and assigns meaning to stimuli we pay attention to. We may use it without 'thinking' about it. It looks for shortcuts when processing information e.g., patterns of letters or words in assigning meanings. The working memory works in conjunction with the long term memory.
- c) **Short term memory** – Once information is interpreted in working memory it is either sent to the short term or the long term memory. The short term memory is part of the memory that acts as a temporary storage place for information. The information stored in short term memory is that which we want to use immediately but not necessarily in future. It is the least efficient of our memory resources because information stored here is easily forgotten unless some strategy like rehearsal is used. Unfortunately, most people, students included, rely on short term memory for information that deserves to be recalled in the long term.

- d) **Long term memory** – This is the permanent storage place for information including past experiences, language, values, knowledge, images of people, memories of sights, sounds, smells and even fantasies. Unlike short term memory, long term memory has no known limitation on the quantity or duration of stored information. Long term memory is organized in schema, which are organizational filing systems for thoughts held in long term memory. We access such information through stimulus cues that constitute words, images, sights, smells or tastes that serve as triggers, which signal the mind to activate information held in schema. If we encounter information for first time, which is not in the long-term memory, a new schema will be created, and this information stored. The long-term memory plays a key role in the listening process because it is instrumental in recalling stored information and helps in creating meaning between what we hear and our background knowledge.

2.6 Types of Listening

There are various types of listening, which can be used for various purposes either independently or in combination. These are:

- a) **Active listening** – It involves listening with a purpose and comprises:
- i) Listening carefully using all our available senses.
 - ii) Paraphrasing what we hear both mentally and verbally.
 - iii) Checking our understanding to ensure accuracy.
 - iv) Providing feedback positively or negatively.
- b) **Empathetic listening** – It is a form of active listening where we attempt to understand the other person by perceiving their world view as if it is our own. It is putting we in the shoes of another person to feel and understand what the person is going through. This kind is very useful in sustaining relationships, counseling process, resolving disputes, as well as dealing with traumatic situations.
- c) **Critical listening** – This is listening those analyses, evaluates, critiques or challenges a speaker's message by evaluating its accuracy, meaningfulness and utility. This goes hand in hand with critical thinking and it involves asking question such as:
- i) Is the speaker's message possible? Is it realistic?
 - ii) Does the speaker back up his or her claims? Are these claims reliable?

iii) Is the speaker credible or an authority?

iv) Is the message free of contradiction and inconsistencies?

Critical listening is very useful when we are confronted with persuasive messages such as advertisements, political communications, propaganda and the like.

d) **Listening for enjoyment** – This type of listening helps us to relax like when we enjoy listening to, for instance, music.

e) **Reflective listening**

This refers to attentively listening to the speaker's actual words, as well as tone of voice, and observing the body language and emotions displayed. Reflective listening is particularly an important tool in one-on-one situations. It is not practical in a speaker-audience situation.

f) **Passive listening**

This means concentrating at a low level and absorbing just enough of the speaker's words to stay involved in a conversation or speech. Such listening is characterized by:

- Listeners remembering little of what is said
- Listeners let the speaker's inflection or tone of voice signal when they should react by nodding, smiling or saying, "I see"
- Listeners may suggest that the speaker has the listener's attention, even though that may not be the case
- It is appropriate when you listen for pleasure and when it doesn't matter whether you retain what you hear.

2.7 Effective Listening Strategies

Effective listening is a life-long skill that is of paramount importance in academic life. There are various ways of improving listening skills that can make your life in academics and beyond very fruitful. Strategies that improve your listening skills include:

- a) **Listen and think critically** – This involves analyzing the speaker, the situation and the message in order to make critical judgment about messages being presented.
- b) **Identifying and understanding barriers to the listening process and genuinely working towards eliminating them.** Such barriers may include noise of various types, which should be eliminated in the listening process.

- c) **Identifying patterns in what we are listening to** – Understanding the overall message, its main points and the supporting points is essential in having a graphical impression of messages and is an important aid in the recall process.
- d) **Applying memory retention skills** such as:
 - i) Rehearsing and rephrasing what we listen to.
 - ii) Using mnemonic devices (using a series of letters forming a meaningful or pronounceable word where each letter stands for a particular concept, idea or point for easy recall).

2.8 Improving Listening skills

Listening behavior also varies from culture to culture. For instance, African listeners may look away from you instead of maintaining eye contact, while Japanese listeners often close their eyes when they are concentrating.

However, even such cultural orientations are not an excuse to effective listening.

You can use these five strategies to enhance, reinforce and develop your listening skills:

- *Read* to gain background information
- *Repeat* a person's name when you are introduced to someone
- *Ask* questions to clarify information
- *Take* good notes
- *Use* a tape recorder, when permitted, to record a lecture or a meeting

Good listening skills enable you:

- To absorb an instructor's lectures, explanations and directions for assignments
- Understand what the speaker is saying
- Combined with note-taking, listening skills enable you record information and review it at a later time

2.8.1 Overcoming listening barriers

Becoming an effective listener requires conscious effort and practice.

Listening barriers are any distractions that interfere with listening, for example:

- Not concentrating on what is being said
- Being distracted by noise

- Talking instead of listening
- Having preconceived thoughts and opinions
- Not being interested in what is being said

These can be overcome through:

- Concentrate on the speaker's message – it is your responsibility to stay focused.
- Use filters to manage and control noise – control the two basic kinds of noise; 1) external noise, which includes sounds from conversations, radio, television, CD players, machinery etc. and 2) internal noise, which includes distractions such as pain, fatigue, preoccupation with other thoughts, hunger, worry or a personality conflict with the speaker. To this end, you can turn down the volume of unnecessary sounds, take a pain reliever or get enough sleep.
- Resist talking instead of listening – it is impossible to be both sender and receiver of information at the same time. You can even become your own distraction.
- Focus on the message – make sure that your own ideas do not interfere with listening to the ideas of another.
- Listen with a positive attitude – you do not have to agree with the speaker, but good listening requires you to keep an open mind and believe that the speaker might have something useful to offer.

2.8.2 Improving listening skills

1. Paraphrasing: this is summarizing the speaker's message in your own words and allowing the speaker to correct any discrepancies from the intended message. That is, the listener crystallizes his/her own understanding of the content presented.
2. Evaluate your skills: everyone has listening weakness; you must therefore identify your weaknesses.
3. Prepare yourself physically and mentally: listening is a combination of physical and mental activities.
4. Set listening priorities: because you are bombarded with several messages at once, decide which ones deserve your focus.
5. Make efficient use of available time: do not rush through your conversation as you may lack full understanding of the message.

6. Listen attentively: be attentive and show interest in the speaker's message.
7. Listen for ideas and feelings: look out for information as well as the speaker's tone of voice.
8. Establish eye contact: do not stare at the speaker, instead, glance away periodically to reflect on the topic.
9. Use body language to show you are listening: body language can convey your level of interest. Employ appropriate non-verbal cues.
10. Overlook personal characteristics of the speaker: do not prejudge a speaker based on distracting personal characteristics such as mannerisms, voice, speech patterns or appearance.
11. Choose strategic seating: posture can affect listening; therefore, choose a physical location that is conducive, comfortable and practical.
12. Ask questions if permitted: this helps clarify the speaker's information.
13. Take notes: jot down key ideas or concepts for further referencing.

One method to help you retain the content of a speaker's message is to think of the strategies represented by the letters in the sentence "IS A FACT":

Identify – identify the speaker's ideas and connections among the ideas

Summarize – summarize the main points of the message

Assess – assess the correctness or validity of the message

Formulate – formulate appropriate questions

Associate – associate the speaker's ideas with other known concepts

Consider – consider specific ways the information might be used

Take notes – take notes to assist in better recall (to bring to mind)

3.0 SPEAKING SKILLS

3.1 Introduction

These sections will cover the following topics: distinguish between public speaking and conversation, show how to effectively manage stage fright, describe effective public speaking strategies, explain the significance of public speaking to an individual describe the various approaches to a speech, explain the various modes of delivering a speech, explain the use of non-verbal communication cues in public speaking, describe informative and persuasive speeches.

3.2 Importance of Public Speaking

Speaking is an integral part of the communication process. Through speech we express our thoughts which is the major motivation in speaking. Besides, we speak to socialize with others, to gratify the listener and at times to gain some rewards (Pushup & Kumar 2007:11).

When we excel in speech, we may win the favor of the management and get promoted. Speaking skills enables us to present information in a clear, accurate and interesting way. Our speaking styles determines how a message is received and it is an important factor in successful communication. A person acquires a distinctive, unique speaking style through experience, but speaking styles can be improved by conscious effort and practice.

3.3 Public Speaking vs. Conversation

Though public speaking requires almost the same skills as used in ordinary conversation, there is a difference in how you put forth your thought in both situations. The two have both similarities and differences.

3.3.1 Similarities

In both speaking and some conversations, you are required to do the following:

1. Organize your thoughts and ideas and presents them in a persuasive manner e.g., if you want to teach a child about ethical or moral values, you need to organize your ideas and decide how to teach the child the importance of these values.

Similarly, a speaker should organize his/her thoughts before delivering a speech.

2. Tailor your message according to the audiences present. In both cases, one needs to be aware of the audience. The audience will not only determine the content but also the style of delivering it, Communication needs to be audience specific to be effective.
3. In both, to emphasize your thoughts, you may use a few points in the form of stories or anecdotes.
4. Both forms adapt to the feedback of their listener. For instance, you can see that a learner has accepted or understood your point when he or she nods. If you find that the learner is not convinced, you try other ways to prove your point.
5. As you learn to speak more effectively in public, you also learn to communicate more effectively in other situations too like in conversations.

3.3.2 Differences

1. Public speaking has more responsibility than ordinary conversation. This is because it involves addressing a large audience with different backgrounds and different knowledge of the subject.
2. Public speaking is highly structured. There is a structured way of starting and ending the speech whereas, in our everyday conversation, we do not concentrate much on starting our talk with a striking introduction.
3. In public speaking the speaker accomplishes the purpose of the speech in the limited time given to him. Unlike in ordinary conversations, the speaker doesn't allow interruptions.
4. Public speaking demands more detailed preparation, organization, and planning unlike conversation, which is, in most cases is spontaneous talk. In public speaking the speaker should be prepared for the questions that the audience might ask after the speech.
5. Public speaking requires more formal language than is required for a conversation. The use of a slang, jargons and grammar is not encouraged in public speaking.

6. Public speaking demands the proper use of both verbal and non verbal cues. In voice and body language, but special care must be taken for these in case of public speaking.

3.4 Communication Apprehension or Public Speaking Anxiety

Communication apprehension is the feeling of anxiety or dread that can overcome someone who is facing a speech or interpersonal interaction. It is also called stage fright or public speaking anxiety (PSA) as noted by Mjomba (2008, p.10).

O'Hare et al (2007) suggest that feeling nervous before making a speech is not only normal but also desirable. Mjomba (2008) continues to note that, "Most individuals feel that communicating before an audience is risky, thus become fearful about the possibility of failure that they begin to experience negative thoughts even before entering a communication context. Hopson, Hanaki & Lee (2004), Mjomba (2008), p.10) and Lucas (2007), points out that speakers who experience PSA often display the following behaviors.

- i. A quavering or monotone voice that speaks too fast or too slow.
- ii. Interruptions in speech fluency by halting and hunting for words.
- iii. Dry mouth and throat and repeated swallowing. The dryness of the mouth is sometimes known as "cotton mouth."
- iv. Rigid and tense arms and hands
- v. Awkward body movements like swaying, pacing, and shuffling of feet.
- vi. Sweating
- vii. Avoiding eye contact with the audience
- viii. Uttering vocalized pauses like, "eh, well, you know" ... etc.
- ix. Standing as far away as possible from the audience.
- x. Place as many obstacles as possible between them and the audience.

The degree to which people experience apprehension ranges from mild nervousness before beginning to speak to a total inability to say anything. Very few individuals suffer from the more serious form. With practice, you can learn to control or overcome your stage fright and use it to sharpen your performance.

3.4 Strategies for Controlling Stage Fright

1. Select a topic that the audience will find interesting
2. Research your speech thoroughly.
3. Prepare adequately. The best solution for overcoming fear of speaking is preparation. Select an interesting topic, research thoroughly, prepare the material in an organized and interesting fashion and practice well. With this done, you will feel more confident. Confidence is the key to controlling stage fright. If you feel you are in control of the situation, you have less reason to be fearful.
4. Set realistic goals. It is also important to set realistic expectations for yourself. Your first few speeches might not be perfect. After each speech, study the evaluation you receive, determine areas you need to work on, and set clearly defined goals for improvement. Take public speaking one step at a time just as you work for any other skill.
5. Walk to podium calm and confidently because acting confident can make you feel confident.
6. Do not start talking until you feel confident up in front.
7. Look at the people in the audience like those who nod positively, smile, and look attentive.
8. Focus on the message and not on yourself.
9. Focus on the friendly people in the audience like those who nod positively, smile, and look attentive.
10. Be composed, get organized at the podium, and take a deep breath before beginning. When the time comes to deliver your speech, don't rush to begin speaking as soon as you get to the front of the room. Once you get first few words out, you will think less about yourself and more about your subject.
11. Try to burn up some of your nervous energy before you start speaking. Take deep breaths to relax, clench your fists and relax them several times while you are waiting to speak. Try to incorporate physical activity into the speech itself. Don't be afraid to use gestures or to move about if it is natural to do so. Use visual aids or write the most important points on the board.

12. View the audience as your friends and remember that the audience is not your enemy. They share your fears, seldom, if ever, does an audience laugh at a speaker, especially an inexperienced one. Your classmates all feel the same way as you do, and they probably admire you for getting through the speech.
13. Think positive thoughts; remind yourself all the reasons that public speaking is helpful—personally, socially, and professionally.
14. Visualize success
15. Enjoy the occasion.
16. Systematic desensitization; This is repeated exposures to small doses of water makes you apprehensive. E.g., you can speak to a group of people more often for short periods of time.
17. Professional help- If the stage fright is acute, you can seek professional help from trained psychologists or counselors.

3.5 Importance of Public Speaking

There are several benefits or skills that can be learnt or developed from public speaking, and they include.

1. **Organizational skills.** Organizational skills are an important part of composing a speech. In fact, the ability to organize ideas is a skill you will employ before you ever write a speech. In fact, the ability to organize ideas is a skill you will employ before you ever write a speech. In fact, the ability to organize ideas is a skill you will employ before you ever write a speech. The same is true for writing. The organizational skills that are necessary in composing speeches carry over to other areas that require outlining and planning, such as organizing notes or reporting on science experiments.
2. **Writing skills.** Many of the principles you use to compose good speeches are the same as those you need to write well. The practice you gain preparing speeches will improve your ability to express your ideas on paper. You will learn how to get your audience's attention, how to organize clearly and how to support your ideas or opinions. These aspects will benefit you when you write essay assignments in college and write reports in your job.

3. Critical thinking skills. The current educational practices in this country have been accused of having failed to develop critical and analytical thinking abilities in learners. Public speaking skills and related listening skills provide valuable tools for the critical analysis of ideas. By studying the use of supportive materials and persuasive strategies, you will learn to ask questions about the claims speakers make.

By learning to think critically, you will solve both academic and job-related problems and to fulfill your duties as a citizen.

4. Research skills. Public speaking will introduce you to a variety of research materials thus help you develop research skills. These will be useful to you in a wide range of university and job-related activities.
5. Listening skills. Speaking and listening go hand. Whenever someone gives a speech, there is an audience to listen to it. By learning good speaking techniques, you will prepare speeches that are easier for an audience to listen to and understand.

You will also learn how to listen to other speakers to hear all the key points.

By sharpening your listening skills as you analyze your classmate's speeches, you will improve your listening skills in every other listening situations.

6. Self- confidence. Learning the art of public speaking and how to give a speech in front of a group develops your self-confidence. As you become more confident as a public speaker, you will gain confidence in your ability to communicate in general. It will be easier to speak out in small groups and interviews will become easier because you will have learnt techniques to prepare and present information about yourself.

Succeeding as a public speaker can give your self-confidence a tremendous boost.

3.6 Steps in Public Speaking

3.6.1 Planning

Speakers must consider the following four points when planning their speech.

- i. Their subject
- ii. Their audiences
- iii. Themselves as speakers
- iv. Their occasion

Subject

The speaker's direct and indirect experiences are the two general sources of speeches subjects. Direct experience is knowledge obtained from radio, TV reading and listening to other people. Speakers can make more effective presentation with subjects from their direct experiences. Subjects may be divided into three types:

- i. Those which inform e.g., basic principles of organization
- ii. Those which persuade e.g., Abortion should be punished
- iii. Those which entertain e.g., do teachers have private lives?

Audiences

Speakers must consider the knowledge, and the needs of their audiences. They should find out what the members of their audience already know about the subject. They should also know whether the audience wants to hear about a subject people usually listen only when they think the speaker's ideas will be of some benefit to them.

Occasion

Speakers should think carefully about the time and place of their speeches. Is the occasion appropriate for the subject they have chosen?

Specific Aspects of Planning a Speech

When speakers have given carefully thought to their subject, audience, own personality and the occasion, they are ready to plan the speech itself. The main aspects to take into consideration when planning the speech itself are the following:

1. **Purpose** – The speaker should first select their general purpose. Do they wish to present factual information to inform to persuade or to entertain? With their

general purpose in mind, they should prepare a brief statement of their specific purpose.

2. **The main ideas.** The next step should be to select the main ideas or main divisions, of the subject define the subject as stated in the specific purpose by answering the questions who, What, where, when, why, and how? In persuasive speeches, the main ideas ought to be the principal reasons for the desired belief or action. In entertainment speeches, the main ideas should be the divisions of the subject that can be amusing to the audience.
3. **Supporting materials.** After selecting the main ideas, speakers should choose supporting material. This includes such things as description, narration, comparisons, examples, testimony, statistics, demonstration etc. The selection of main ideas and supporting material completes the body (main part) of the speech.
4. **Introduction.** Speaker should next plan the introduction. As Mjomba (2008) notes, the introduction is supposed to grab the attention and interest of the audience. Some of the attention-grabbing devices includes posing a question, telling a brief story making a startling statement or opening with a question. Lucas, (2007) adds that the purpose of all these methods is to create a dramatic, colorful opening that will grab the attention of the audience and made them want to hear more. He also points out that in addition to gaining attention and interest, the introduction should orient your listeners towards the subject matter of your speech. The introduction tells the audience precisely what the speaker intends to do in their speech and what value this topic has for the audience.
5. **Body of the speech.** The speech you will be giving could be organized either chronologically or topically. According to Lucas (2007)" the basic structure of a speech that is chronologically organized follows this pattern: First this happened, then this. On the other hand, the topical method of organization subdivides the speech into its natural, logical, and conventional parts. For example, as Mjomba (2008, P. 18) notes, you may want to discuss your mother's life under three topics, such as, her hobbies, carrier goals and family.'
6. **Conclusion.** Next comes the preparation of a conclusion. As Mjomba (2008, p, 19) notes, you need to accomplish two tasks in the conclusion. First, you should let

the audience know that you are winding up your speech. The conclusion of your speech should have a sense of finality. It needs to be cleverly thought out. In informative speeches, the conclusion should be a summary of the main ideas and the specific purpose. In persuasive speeches, the conclusion should combine a summary with a final appeal to the audience to accept the arguments advanced. Entertainment speeches usually end on a point of great amusement.

7. **Outline.** After all those steps, the speakers should prepare an outline using the main point of the speech.

3.6.2 Delivery of the Speech

The basic modes of delivering a speech include:

1. Manuscript mode
2. Extemporaneous mode
3. Impromptu mode
4. Memorized mode

Let us look at each of these briefly.

3.6.2.1 Manuscript mode _Reading from speech

This is when the entire speech has been written down and it is read word for word.

This is normally used in formal situations such as presenting a paper or speaking on radio or Tv. Reading from the text and looking intermittently at the listeners is probably the most common way of delivering a political speech or making a Presidential address. This method is chosen for those occasions where accuracy is extremely crucial, and the speaker cannot risk even the slightest mistakes or alteration in the meaning of the intended message. Thus, the speaker reads from a meticulously prepared text. It is also used by people who are likely to be quoted like the politicians.

Advantages

- i. One cannot be misquoted
- ii. One cannot forget what to say
- iii. One can do thorough research
- iv. One can retain a copy of the speech

Disadvantages

- i. The speaker can pay more attention to the written speech than to the audience. hence the audience will feel left out.
- ii. It discourages eye contact with the audience.
- iii. It discourages response to the audience feedback. It is not interactive.

3.9.2.2 Extemporaneous mode

In extemporaneous delivery, a speaker delivers a speech from a prepared logical outline.

The speaker prepares everything except the exact words. In this method the speaker doesn't write the whole text on paper, but simply writes the main points in bold, big letters.

The speaker refers to the points and builds up the explanation and discussion as the speech progresses. This is the most effective mode of delivering a speech.

Advantages

- i. It renders the speech the much-needed spontaneity as the speaker can maintain his natural speaking style.
- ii. Enables the speaker to maintain sustained eye contact with the audience. This is possible as they don't have to read the whole text as he simply looks at the notes for the points.
- iii. The speaker can adapt to the topics or situations for which he has not planned.
- iv. The speaker has all the opportunity to respond to the cues from the audience and to decide whether to proceed with further explanations on a given point or not.

Because of these advantages, this mode of delivering a speech is the most frequently chosen style. Despite the need for such thoroughness, this is the most used model for delivering a speech and remains the most flexible, versatile, and expressive mode to deliver a speech.

Disadvantages

- i. One might forget some of the supporting details.
- ii. Digression. Depending on the audience response one might drift from the main points.

- iii. One can easily be misquoted.
- iv. One can beyond the allocated time.

3.9.2.3 Impromptu mode

‘Impromptu’ means on the spot, i.e., without prior preparation. Unlike carefully prepared presentations, impromptu speaking tends to be relatively disorganized, imprecise, and repetitive. They are therefore justified by necessity, e.g., this method calls for a lot of spontaneity-quick assembling of ideas and thoughts, lots of confidence and adequate knowledge. The speaker can adapt to the occasion it is used when one attends a meeting and is unexpectedly called upon to speak. For example, when one notices there is a member of a parliament, preacher or any other important guest and calls them to say something to the audience.

Advantages

- i. It allows the speaker enough eye contact with the audience.
- ii. You can have enough body movement and gestures.

Disadvantages

- i. It is rigid and does not allow the speaker flexibility to adapt to unexpected situations and requirements or to change the contact according to the reaction of the audience while delivering their speech.
- ii. In case a speaker misses a word, the entire speech can be thrown into disarray and probably come to a stop.
- iii. It transmits a sense of monotony and stifles creativity. (Push 2007. 86)

3.9.2.4 Memorized Speech

This is recitation of a written message that the speaker has committed to memory.

Advantages

1. Unlike reading from a manuscript, it helps the speaker. maintain eye contact, move around the stage and use gestures freely.

2. Memorization increases the size and improves the function of memory-related brain structures. Memorization enhances the neurological flexibility of the brain.

Disadvantages

1. Failure of memory.
2. Challenge of maintaining a natural style, including variations in pitch tone, gestures etc.

3.8 TYPES OF SPEECHES

3.8.1 Informative Speeches

This entails speaking with an intent to inform or shed light on a subject by sharing facts that you have learned through experience, observation, writing and or reading. Here, the focus of the speaker is to provide required information on an issue.

Providing information is a task we undertake hundreds times each day and is one of the most common and important forms of communication. Yet the techniques for providing information efficiently, gracefully, and in a way that will interest the listener are not well known. A public lecture, status report and briefing are common informative speeches.

3.8.1.2 Types of informative presentations

There are four categories of informative presentations which are:

- i. Reports – these describes the state of an operation. They are usually (but not always) given by subordinates to their superior to keep them informed and help them make decisions.
Some reports are frequent and informal, while others are formal.
- ii. Briefs. – These are short talks that inform an audience about specific area in which new knowledge has been discovered. The executive chef of a restaurant might brief workers about the details of a new menu. Nurses and police officers

attend briefings before each shift to update them on the current situations.

- iii. Explanations-these increases the listeners understanding of a subject. For example, an orientation ceremony for university freshers falls into this category. When implementing change in a firm, good managers gather their employees and explain how the change will affect each one of them. Sometimes, explanations are aimed at external audiences.
- iv. Training. This teaches listeners how to do something. It can be informal or highly structured,like ranging from the simple advice to transferring a telephone call to a week-long seminar on accounting principles for managers of a firm.

3.8.1.3 Goals of an Informative Speech

According to Mckerrow et al (2003), your goal as an informative speaker is to make it easy for your listeners to acquire and new information. In addition to using motivational appeals three other tactics will ensure that your listeners understand and remember what you say. These are:

- i. Clarity: Their clearer your message the better they will follow your ideas.
- ii. Association: Associating new ideas with familiar ones will also assist in their understanding.
- iii. Visualization: Visualizing ideas through words in a manner that is relevant to their experience will help them to remember. Ultimately, your goal is to communicate in a manner that is directly relevant to the lives of your listeners.

3.8.1.4 Organizing Informative Messages

The way you structure your message will affect how well the audience understand it. Make your ideas easy to follow by starting with an overall picture, background information then emphasize important points.

3.8.1.5 Developing Informative Speech

When you prepare a speed to inform, be aware of the situation, purpose, and audience before you selectmethod of development.

3.8.1.6 Strategies for Effective Informative Speaking

1. Consider how relevant and useful the information will be for the audience. You must motivate an audience to listen. In a sense, this is the persuasive element in an information speech. Before members of an audience are willing to listen, they must first be convinced they need to know the information you are sharing.
2. Be sure the information is new to the audience. If you have conducted a thorough audience analysis, this shouldn't be a problem. If the audience already knows all or most of what you are saying, you haven't achieved the purpose of an informative speech. You haven't increased the audience's knowledge of a topic or understanding of it.
3. Be sure that your introduction gets the audience's attention, creates interests, and makes the topic clear. It should also forecast the main ideas.
4. Your conclusion should summarize the major points.
5. Avoid information overload. Remember that you can't cover everything about a topic. Narrow the topic and select the information that is most relevant to the audience. If you give the audience too much information, especially in a new topic, you will probably lose their attention (Diana 1989:340)
6. Cover only necessary information_ as an informative speaker, you will usually be far more knowledgeable about the topic than the audience to whom you speak. This knowledge is both a blessing and a potential curse. If you cover your topic in too much detail, you are likely to bore or even antagonize your listeners.
7. Avoid jargon. If you overwhelm your audience with too much specialized terminology, they will become so confused and bored. Tell people what they need to know and in language they will understand.
8. Link the topic to the audience. Make your topic audience specific and relevant.
9. Link the familiar to the unfamiliar. Research has shown that people have a bigger chance of understanding a new concept when it bears some relationship to information they already know. With your familiar reference point listeners may have trouble understanding even a clear definition.
10. Involve the audience. Listeners who are actively involved in presentation will understand and remember the material far better than will passive listeners.

3.8.2 Persuasive Speeches

Persuasion refers to communication intended to change attitudes or behaviors. It means getting the audience to agree with you or share your view. To persuade the audience, a public speaker must interest and inform them.

3.8.2.1 The Goal of Persuasive Speech

The goal of the speech is to persuade, or to change, create or reinforce attitudes or behavior. A good persuasive strategy-a plan used to convince people of a speaker's opinion begins with knowing your audience. Consider what is appropriate, appealing, and understandable to that audience and then build your argument.

3.8.2.2 Types of Persuasive Presentation

Most persuasive presentations in business fall into one of the following four categories:

- i. Sales presentation
- ii. Proposals
- iii. Motivational speeches
- iv. Good willing speeches
- v. Political campaigns
- vi. Negotiation and conflict management and several others.

Sales Presentations. Sales- people make presentations about such diverse goods and services as real estate, insurance, merchandise, advertising space etc.

Proposals. In an organization, the goal of most proposals is to persuade high management to act. Many involve plans for a new program such as a new product line. Others involve requests to resources like additional staff, larger budgets, or new equipment.

Motivational Speeches. These can combine the oppressive elements of a bad sermon and a high school pep rally, at their worst. On the other hand, when delivered effectively and at the proper time, such presentations can produce good results. For instance, people like David Goggins, Les Brown and James Clear.

Goodwill Speeches. Representatives or organizations frequently speak to audience to promote interest or support to their organizations. A corporate recruiter addressing graduating seniors and a bank economist explaining economic forecasts are making speeches of goodwill.

3.8.3.3 Occasions when you can use a persuasive speech

- i. In job interviews where you will be trying to persuade the employer that you are the best person for the job.
- ii. Work groups where you will need to convince your co-workers or boss the best way to solve a problem.
- iii. As a member of your community, you will have to speak persuasively as a member of PTA, church group or charity organizations on many issues.
- iv. Leadership requires that you have persuasive skills.

3.8.3.4 Ethical Considerations

As Mjomba (2008, p. 80) notes, “when attempting to persuade an audience, ethical considerations should play a role in your speech planning process” “Ethics, often defined as a set of shared beliefs about what behaviors are correct or incorrect, are a vital component of any public speech” (Turman & Fraleigh, 2003). There is more to public speaking than just presenting your speech in a way that will create the highest degree of agreement from your audience. Turman & Fraleigh (2003) argue that “speakers should ethically treat their audience the same way they would wish to be treated as an audience member”. Bearing this in mind, you are expected among other things to cite your sources properly, not to alter data or quotations to appear more persuasive. You should have your audience’s best interest at heart.

3.8.3.5 Organizing Persuasive Message

The way you structure your message plays a major role in determining how successful you will be at persuading an audience.

The various organizational plans with the consideration of choosing each are as follows:

1. **Problem – solution.** This plan first persuades the audience that something is wrong with the present situation and then suggests how to remedy the situation. This plan works especially well when your audience does not feel a strong need to change from the status quo and needs convincing that a problem exists.
2. **Comparative advantages.** A comparative advantage organization plan puts several alternatives side by side to show why yours is the best. This strategy is especially useful when the audience is considering an idea that competes with the one you are advocating.
3. **Criteria satisfaction.** This plan sets up criteria that the audience will accept and then show how your idea or product meets the criteria. It does not usually consider alternative ideas. Thus, it is a good approach when your audience isn't likely to think of alternative plans.
4. **Motivated sequence.** The motivated-sequence organizational plan has a five-step scheme designed to boost the involvement and interest of the audience. These are:
 - i. **Attention** – Capture the attention of the audience by introducing the problem in an interesting manner.
 - ii. **Need** – Explain the problem clearly and completely. **Satisfaction** – Present your solution to the problem. Provide enough support to prove that the solution is workable and that it will indeed solve the problem.
 - iii. **Visualization** – Describe clearly what will happen in your proposal if adopted so that the audience has a clear mental picture of how the proposal will solve the problem.
 - iv. **Action** - Call for response from your audience. Explain what listeners can do to solve the problem.

3.8.3.6 Strategies of Effective Persuasion

A presentation's effectiveness in persuading the audience will be fostered if it takes advantage of the following principles.

1. Appeal to the needs of the audience.

2. Have a realistic goal – Even the best presentation can't accomplish miracles. Asking audience members to accept an idea that they strongly oppose can backfire. Social scientists have refined this common-sense principle into social judgement theory. This theory helps a speaker decide how to craft their arguments by identifying the range of possible opinions listeners might have about a speaker's argument. The theory teaches a very practical reason about how much to ask your audience. Rather than asking for their acceptance of your proposal, you can ask them to simply recognize the fact.
3. Focus appeals on the critical audience segment – Sometimes one or two listeners have the power to approve or reject your appeal. In such cases, it is important to identify the interest, needs, attitudes and prejudices of the key decision makers and then focus your appeal towards them.
4. Defer the Thesis with a Hostile Audience. For example, if you believe the thesis will not be received well or if an audience hears the news too early, they will be too upset to accept or even listen to it. However, a presentation with a deferred thesis still needs an introduction to capture the attention of the audience, and to demonstrate the importance of the topic and orient the listeners to what will follow.
5. Present enough evidence to support claims. Give a precedent, or a factual example from the past that supports your view of the current situation. In general, positive precedents are more effective and appealing. You may use examples or stories, comparisons, or citations. When your goals are to persuade an audience, the generous use of support is especially important.
6. Respond to objections i.e., consider citing opposing ideas. Anticipate opposing views and answer these objections in your presentation. Research indicates that it is generally better to mention and then refute ideas that oppose yours than to ignore them. There are three situations where it is especially important to forewarn listeners about opposing ideas. These are:
 - i. When the audience disagrees with your position – with hostile listeners, it's wise to compare their position and yours, showing the desirability for

your thesis.

- ii. When the audience know both sides of the issue.
 - iii. When the audience will soon hear your viewpoint criticized or another one promoted.
7. Call for fairness. Ask listeners to see beyond their disagreements and consider what is fair and just.
 8. Adapt to the cultural style of your audience. The cultural background of your listeners may affect the way they respond to various types of persuasive appeals e.g., intensity or emotional appeals. For example, the traditional European – American ideal situation is to communicate without becoming too excited, while other cultures, like those of most Africans may be more expressive.
 9. Predict Results. This helps the audience to see the possible results that could occur from deciding or not deciding in your favor.

NB: To convince listeners of your opinion, use and personalize strategies that are most appropriate to your audience and situation.

3.8.3.7 Speaker's Credibility

Credibility is the persuasive force that comes from the audience's belief in and respect for the speaker. When your audience has little time or inclination to examine your evidence and reasoning in detail, it will rely almost exclusively on your credibility to decide whether to accept your claims.

A speaker whom the audience consider credible will be readily acceptable. To succeed as a public speaker, therefore, you need to build a rapport with your audience. It doesn't necessarily mean that the audience likes you. This means you have done what is necessary to make you a good speaker. You must make sure that the audience trusts in what you have to say, and they feel that you care for them. A speaker's credibility is, in fact, the epitome of what they already know about the speaker, the impression the speaker makes during the speech and how the speaker is introduced or introduces him/herself. In public speaking situations, it contributes immediately to the effectiveness

of the speech. A speaker to whom the audience considers credible will be readily acceptable.

3.8.3.7.1 Factors that affect a Speaker's Credibility are:

Sociability, Dynamism, Physical attractiveness, Expertise, Consistency, Honesty, Concern for the message and Concern for listeners.

3.8.3.7.2 Tips for Building Speaker's Credibility

As everything you say in a speech will affect your credibility, you should say and do things in such a way that it will make you appear capable and trustworthy. The following tips will help:

1. Demonstrate your competence by demonstrating your knowledge of the subject, making your credentials known and by demonstrating your abilities.
2. Good organization will improve credibility.
3. Use appropriate, clear, and vivid language.
4. Ensure fluent and dynamic delivery with a strong evidence and reasoning.
5. Earn the trust of your audience by honesty and impartiality on your part.
6. Empathize your similarity to the audience. Audiences are most willing to accept the ideas of a speaker whose attitudes and behaviors are like their own. Establish common ground between you and listeners early in your presentation.
7. Increase your Appeal to the Audience – Listeners are more persuaded by speakers they find appealing in some way e.g., appearance.
8. Demonstrate your sincerity. Speakers perceived as believing strongly in their subjects are more persuasive than unenthusiastic ones. Sincerity is only impressive if the audience detects it; however, unfortunately, some speakers don't show their enthusiasm and so reduce their effectiveness.

3.9 Features of the Voice that can be used for Effective Public Speaking

As Mjomba (2008, p.58) notes, "your voice is a powerful instrument of expression. Used properly, it should express who you are and convey your message in a way that engages the listeners. Whatever your voice, you can be sure it is unique". According to Lucas,

(2007), The eight aspects of speech you should work on to control are: volume, pitch, rate, pauses, variety, pronunciation, articulation and dialect.

- i. **Volume:** This is the loudness or softness of the softness of the speaker's voice. If you speak too loudly, your speakers may think you are not courteous. If you speak too softly, they will not understand, and they might think you are not confident or you are not well prepared. Balance your volume to suit the audience and the occasion.
- ii. **Pitch:** These are the vocal notes we hit while we speak. It is the highness or lowness of the speaker's voice. Changes in pitch are known as reflections. They voice luster, warmth and vitality. It is the inflection in your voice that reveals whether you are asking a question or making a statement, and whether you are being sincere or sarcastic. People who do not use inflection to convey meaning and emotion are said to speak in monotones, a constant pitch, or constant tone of voice.
- iii. **Rate:** This is the speed at which a person speaks. Two obvious faults to avoid are speaking so slowly that your listeners become bored so quickly that they lose track of your ideas.
- iv. **Pauses:** This is the intended silence during a speech. Learning how and when to pause is a major challenge to most beginning speakers. As you gain more experience in public speaking, you will discover how useful a pause can be. It can signal the end of a thought unit, given an ideal time to sink in, and lend dramatic impact to a statement.
- v. **Vocal variety:** This is the changes in a speaker's rate, pitch, and volume that give the voice variety and expressiveness. As Mjomba (2008, p. 58) puts it, "A boring unchanging voice is just as bad to speech making as a boring unchanging routine is to daily life".
- vi. **Pronunciation:** Pronouncing words in English can be very difficult for students who are not native speakers of the language. Practicing your speech in front of as many trusted friends as you can help you to correct your pronunciations. If you have any doubts about the pronunciation of a word, check it in the dictionary.

- vii. **Articulation:** This is the physical production of speech sounds like saying “R” instead of “L”. Work on identifying and eliminating your most common errors. Persistent practice can eliminate this.
- viii. **Dialect:** This is a variety, of language distinguished by various variations of accent, grammar, or vocabulary. There is no such thing as a right or wrong dialect (Mjomba, 2008, p. 59). Our regional or ethnic background usually shapes our dialect. Every dialect is “right” for the people who use it. When is a given dialect appropriate in public speaking? The answer depends above all on the composition of your audience.

3.10 The Body Aspects Of Speech Delivery

The following four aspects, posture, facial expression, gestures and eye contact, all affect the way listeners respond to you as a speaker. The study of these and other motions used to communicate is called **kinesics**. Lucas (2007) points out the major aspects of physical action that will affect the outcome of your speech. These are as follows:

- i. **Personal Appearance:** Several studies have confirmed that appearance plays an important role in speech making. Listeners always see you before they hear you. Regardless of the speaking situation, you should try to evoke a favorable first impression. An impression that is likely to make the listeners be more receptive to what you say.
- ii. **Create a sense of movement:** Inexperienced public speakers are not sure about what to do with their body while giving a speech. Unless your movement is restricted by the microphone or the podium, do not stay in one fixed place. Have an appropriate and meaningful movement. Speakers who write on the board as they speak must try not to show their back to the audience. This can be achieved either by writing the information on the board before speaking or by using a poster, power point etc.
- iii. **Gestures:** These are the motions of a speaker’s hands or arms during a speech. Competent gestures can add to the impact of the speech. However, whatever gestures you make, they should not draw attention to you and distract the listeners from your message. They should appear natural and spontaneous, and

help to clarify and reinforce your ideas, and they should be suited to the audience and the occasion.

- iv. **Eye – contact:** This is the sustained and meaningful contact with your eyes. It can show approval or disapproval. As Mjomba (2008 p. 60) points out, “messages from the manipulation of the eyeballs are so revealing that we think of the eyes as the windows of the soul. The audience look at them to help them measure the truthfulness, intelligence, attitudes and feelings of a speaker”.

3.11 Visual Aids

This is anything that is used to enhance speech delivery. It can include the way you dress, e.g., wearing a police uniform when talking about the police, bring a guitar to talk about music etc.

Types of Visual aids:

- a) **Chalk or white board** to write the topic and the main ideas of your speech
- b) **Posters:** The information in the poster should be the one that is difficult to convey or understand through listening.
- c) **Pie chart, bar graphs and line graphs** to compare and construct different types of information e.g., different academic performance for different years.
- d) **Overhead projectors**, movies, slides, power points etc.

Helpful hints for using visual aids

- I. Visual aids need documentation. You can include the documentation on the visual aid to show the listeners where you got it from.
- II. Do not talk to your visual aid. Keep eyes on your audience.
- III. Display visual aids only when using them, otherwise they will distract the audience.
- IV. Make sure that everyone in the room can see the visual aid. Leave the visual aid long enough for the complete assimilation of information by the audience. It is bad to have a half – read visual aid taken away.
- V. Use a pointer to point at your visual aid. This prevents you from blocking the audience.

3.12 Topic Summary

This section has focused on the place of Public Speaking as a component of Communication Skills. More precisely, it treated a number of issues in public speaking e.g., stage fright, speech preparation and organization, non – verbal cues, informative and persuasive speeches. Essential strategies and suggestions have been given for the development and use of these elements in fostering good public speaking skills. We hope you found them useful.

3.13 Topic Review Questions

- i. Define public speaking
- ii. Compare and contrast public speaking and conversation
- iii. Describe the strategies that you would use to overcome communication apprehension / stage fright.
- iv. Discuss the four basic modes of delivering a speech.
- v. State four advantages of extempore speaking
- vi. What are the main undoing of a memorized speech delivery?
- vii. Identify five features of voice that can be used to make a speech lively.
- viii. Discuss the various goals of information speaking.
- ix. Discuss the strategies for effective public speaking.
- x. Identify four types of persuasive presentations.
- xi. What strategies would you use to build your credibility as a speaker?